Deliberation and Turnout in Benin: A Replication and Extension

Wantchekon and Guardado (2024), *American Political Science Review* | Quantitative Analysis in International Relations, Rio Ikeuchi

Clara Wei

July 27, 2026

```
library(tidyverse)
library(haven)
library(fixest)
library(knitr)
```

```
base <- "/Users/clarawei/school/study abroad/classes/quant analysis in international relations/

df <- read_dta(file.path(base, "Data", "votingdata_final.dta")) |>
  zap_labels() |>
  rename(
    treat     = treat_vil,        # 1 = town-hall village, 0 = control
    voteshare = votes_treat_cand  # vote share of the candidate who campaigned there
  )
```

```
# Pulls one coefficient out of a fixest model and returns a tidy row.
# Used to build every results table, so no raw R output appears in the paper.
grab <- function(model, term, label, communes) {
  ct <- coeftable(model)
  data.frame(
    Specification = label,
    Estimate      = ct[term, "Estimate"],
    `Std. Error`  = ct[term, "Std. Error"],
    `p-value`     = ct[term, "Pr(>|t|)"],
    Villages      = nobs(model),
    Communes      = communes,
    check.names   = FALSE, row.names = NULL
  )
}
```

1 Introduction

Election campaigns in much of sub-Saharan Africa are organized around large public rallies at which a candidate or a local broker addresses an audience, distributes small gifts, and departs. Voters listen but do not get the chance to speak. This paper replicates and extends a field experiment that

asked whether replacing that format with a deliberative one changes how citizens vote.

Research question. Does deliberative campaigning in small town-hall meetings where voters discuss a candidate's policy platform and can respond to it increase electoral participation and shift vote choice, relative to the standard rally?

Why it matters. Two mechanisms make the research question interesting. If campaigns influence voters mainly by transmitting information about platforms, then a format that allows questions and discussion should transmit more of it, and should therefore move votes toward the candidate who uses it. If deliberation instead works by raising the perceived value of participation itself, then it should raise turnout without necessarily benefiting the candidate who paid for it. The two mechanisms make different predictions, and the experiment can distinguish them. The answer also has practical stakes: if deliberation mobilizes voters without winning votes, candidates have little private incentive to adopt it, even where it improves the quality of representation.

Approach. Wantchekon and Guardado (2024) ran a block-randomized field experiment during Benin's 2011 presidential election. Working with the three leading candidates, they randomly assigned 150 villages, drawn from 30 communes, either to receive town-hall meetings or to receive the usual rally. Outcomes were collected directly from polling stations. I replicate the two main village-level results — the effect on official turnout and on official vote share — and then extend the analysis in two directions. First, I re-assess the statistical evidence for the turnout result using randomization inference, which relies on the known assignment mechanism rather than on a large-sample approximation. Second, I disaggregate the pooled treatment variable into candidate-specific treatments, to test whether the effect reported for "opposition" candidates is common to both of them.

Main findings. The replication succeeded: all six village-level coefficients match the published table to three decimal places. Turnout is 3.31 percentage points higher in town-hall villages, while official vote share is unchanged. The extensions qualify the first of these results and refine the second. Randomization inference returns a p-value of about 0.066 for the turnout effect, against the 0.043 reported in the paper, so the headline result is significant at the 10 percent level but not at the conventional 5 percent level once the actual randomization procedure is used for inference. The vote-share null is unaffected by the choice of inference method and is precisely estimated, ruling out effects larger than roughly four percentage points in either direction. Disaggregating by candidate shows that the reported "opposition" effect rests overwhelmingly on one of the two opposition candidates, since 90 of the 110 opposition villages were assigned to a single coalition.

2 Data

The data come from the replication package for Wantchekon and Guardado (2024), deposited at the APSR Dataverse (https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/PRYYZ5). I use `votingdata_final.dta`, the village-level file underlying the paper's Tables 3 and 4. Each of the 150 rows is one village. Turnout and vote shares were recorded by the research team directly from polling-station returns, so the outcomes are administrative counts rather than survey responses.

The key variables are:

- `treat` (`treat_vil` in the original file): 1 if the village received town-hall meetings, 0 if it received the standard rally.
- `turnout`: ballots cast as a percentage of registered voters.

- `voteshare` (`votes_treat_cand`): percentage of votes cast in the village for the candidate who campaigned there.
- `commune`: the district that serves as the randomization block.
- `yayi_treat`, `abt_treat`, `un_treat`: treatment indicators specific to each of the three candidates — the incumbent Yayi Boni, Abdoulaye Bio Tchané (ABT), and the Union fait la Nation coalition (UN).
- `yayi_commune`, `abt_commune`, `un_commune`: which candidate was assigned to campaign in each commune.

Table 1 summarizes the design. Treatment was assigned within commune, two villages treated and three control in every one of the 30 communes, giving 60 treated and 90 control villages. The three candidates were allocated to disjoint sets of communes, which is important for the second extension: with commune fixed effects, each candidate's treatment effect is identified only from variation inside that candidate's own communes.

```
design <- df |>
  mutate(Candidate = case_when(
    yayi_commune == 1 ~ "Yayi Boni (incumbent)",
    un_commune   == 1 ~ "UN coalition (opposition)",
    abt_commune  == 1 ~ "Bio Tchané (opposition)"
  )) |>
  group_by(Candidate) |>
  summarise(
    Communes = n_distinct(commune),
    Villages = n(),
    Treated  = sum(treat),
    Control  = sum(1 - treat),
    .groups  = "drop"
  ) |>
  arrange(desc(Villages))

kable(design, booktabs = TRUE,
      caption = "Experimental design by campaigning candidate")
```

Table 1: Experimental design by campaigning candidate

Candidate	Communes	Villages	Treated	Control
UN coalition (opposition)	18	90	36	54
Yayi Boni (incumbent)	8	40	16	24
Bio Tchané (opposition)	4	20	8	12

3 Analysis

3.1 Identification strategy

Treatment was assigned by the researchers through a known random procedure, so this is an experiment in the sense defined in class: the assignment mechanism is probabilistic and known.

Randomization was blocked, meaning it was carried out separately within each commune rather than across the whole country at once.

In potential outcomes notation, let $Y_{jc}(1)$ be the turnout village j in commune c would record if assigned town-hall meetings and $Y_{jc}(0)$ the turnout it would record if assigned the standard rally. Only one is ever observed. Because assignment was random within commune, treatment is independent of potential outcomes conditional on the block:

$$\{Y_{jc}(1), Y_{jc}(0)\} \perp T_{jc} \mid c.$$

Under this assumption, the difference in mean outcomes between treated and control villages within the same commune is an unbiased estimate of the average treatment effect. The conditioning on c is essential. Comparing treated villages in one commune to control villages in another would confound the treatment with regional differences in wealth, ethnic composition, and baseline political engagement. Commune fixed effects restrict the comparison to villages that were genuinely randomized against one another.

Two further assumptions are worth stating. First, no interference between villages: turnout in one village must not depend on whether a neighboring village received town hall meetings. Villages in the same commune are geographically close, so spillover, whether it was through word of mouth or shared markets, is possible. If treated villages raised turnout in nearby control villages, the estimates below understate the true effect. Second, the estimand is an intention to treat effect. It compares villages assigned to town hall meetings against villages assigned to rallies, not individuals who actually attended a meeting. Since attendance was voluntary and averaged well below full participation, the effect on those who attended is larger than the effect reported here.

3.2 Empirical specification

The replication estimates, for outcome Y_{jc} in village j of commune c:

$$Y_{jc} = \alpha_c + \beta T_{jc} + u_{jc},$$

where T_{jc} is the town-hall indicator, α_c are commune fixed effects absorbing everything constant within a commune, and β is the parameter of interest. Following the original paper I use heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. I estimate this equation for turnout and for vote share, on the full sample and separately on opposition-assigned and incumbent-assigned communes.

The second extension replaces the single pooled treatment with three candidate-specific indicators:

$$Y_{jc} = \alpha_c + \beta_1 \mathrm{Yayi}_{jc} + \beta_2 \mathrm{ABT}_{jc} + \beta_3 \mathrm{UN}_{jc} + u_{jc}.$$

Because each commune is assigned to exactly one candidate, and commune fixed effects are included, each β is identified purely within that candidate's communes. The pooled specification implicitly assumes $\beta_2 = \beta_3$; this specification tests it.

The first extension changes not the specification but how its p-value is computed, and is described in Section 4.3.

4 Coding and Findings

4.1 Replication of the turnout result

```
m1 <- feols(turnout ~ treat | commune, data = df, vcov = "hetero")
m2 <- feols(turnout ~ treat | commune,
            data = filter(df, opp_commune  == 1), vcov = "hetero")
m3 <- feols(turnout ~ treat | commune,
            data = filter(df, yayi_commune == 1), vcov = "hetero")
```

```
bind_rows(
  grab(m1, "treat", "All communes",        communes = 30),
  grab(m2, "treat", "Opposition communes", communes = 22),
  grab(m3, "treat", "Incumbent communes",  communes = 8)
) |>
  kable(booktabs = TRUE, digits = 3,
        caption = "Effect of town-hall meetings on official turnout (percentage points). Commu
```

Table 2: Effect of town-hall meetings on official turnout (percentage points). Commune fixed effects; heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. Replicates Table 3, Panel A of the original paper.

Specification	Estimate	Std. Error	p-value	Villages	Communes
All communes	3.309	1.619	0.043	150	30
Opposition communes	2.653	1.572	0.095	110	22
Incumbent communes	5.111	4.301	0.244	40	8

All three coefficients reproduce the published values exactly (3.309, 2.653 and 5.111, with standard errors 1.619, 1.572 and 4.301). Turnout in town-hall villages is 3.31 percentage points higher than in control villages in the same commune, against a control-group mean of about 85 percent.

The incumbent estimate deserves care. Its point estimate is nearly twice the opposition estimate, but its standard error is almost three times larger, and a conventional confidence interval comfortably includes zero. This reflects the sample: only 8 communes and 40 villages were assigned to the incumbent. The correct reading is that the data cannot determine whether the incumbent's town halls were more or less effective than the opposition's, not that they had no effect. Absence of statistical significance here reflects imprecision rather than an estimated zero.

4.2 Replication of the vote-share result

```
v1 <- feols(voteshare ~ treat | commune, data = df, vcov = "hetero")
v2 <- feols(voteshare ~ treat | commune,
            data = filter(df, opp_commune  == 1), vcov = "hetero")
v3 <- feols(voteshare ~ treat | commune,
            data = filter(df, yayi_commune == 1), vcov = "hetero")
```

```r
bind_rows(
  grab(v1, "treat", "All communes",         communes = 30),
  grab(v2, "treat", "Opposition communes", communes = 22),
  grab(v3, "treat", "Incumbent communes",  communes = 8)
) |>
  kable(booktabs = TRUE, digits = 3,
        caption = "Effect of town-hall meetings on official vote share for the campaigning can
```

Table 3: Effect of town-hall meetings on official vote share for the campaigning candidate (percentage points). Replicates Table 4, Panel A of the original paper.

Specification	Estimate	Std. Error	p-value	Villages	Communes
All communes	-0.196	2.128	0.927	150	30
Opposition communes	-0.048	2.514	0.985	110	22
Incumbent communes	-0.604	4.047	0.882	40	8

These also reproduce the published values exactly. The estimated effect on vote share is -0.196 percentage points, with a 95 percent confidence interval of [-4.41, 4.02].

This is a precise null rather than a noisy one. The interval excludes effects larger than about four percentage points in either direction, which is small relative to the vote shares involved — the campaigning candidate averaged roughly 53 percent in these villages. Treatment therefore explains essentially none of the residual variation in vote share once commune fixed effects are accounted for.

Taken together, the two replicated tables support the second of the two mechanisms set out in the introduction. Deliberative campaigning brought more people to the polls without redistributing votes toward the candidate who provided it.

4.3 Extension 1: Randomization inference

4.3.1 Motivation

The turnout result is statistically marginal. Its p-value under the reported heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors is 0.043, which clears the 5 percent threshold by a small margin. This makes it worth asking how much the threshold judgment depends on how the p-value was computed.

Robust standard errors justify inference by appeal to large-sample behavior: they describe how much the estimate would vary across repeated samples drawn from a large population. That approximation is reliable when the sample is large. Here there are 150 villages and 30 commune fixed effects, which is not obviously large enough for the approximation to be trusted at the margin.

Randomization inference offers an alternative that does not depend on a large-sample approximation. It uses the assignment mechanism itself, which in an experiment is known exactly. The procedure tests the *sharp null hypothesis* that treatment had no effect on any village whatsoever:

$$H_0 : Y_{jc}(1) = Y_{jc}(0) \quad \text{for every village } j.$$

This is stronger than the usual null of zero average effect, and that strength is what makes the test possible. If the sharp null were true, each village's observed turnout would have been identical under either assignment. The observed turnout figures can therefore be held fixed while the treatment labels are reassigned according to the original randomization procedure, and the estimate recomputed. Repeating this many times traces out the distribution of estimates that the design would produce if town-hall meetings did nothing. The p-value is the proportion of that distribution at least as far from zero as the estimate actually obtained.

The reassignment must reproduce the real procedure. Because treatment was assigned within commune (two of five villages in each) the permutation is carried out separately within each commune, preserving both the block structure and the number of treated villages per block. Permuting across all 150 villages would simulate a randomization that never occurred and would generate the wrong null distribution.

This is the sense in which the approach improves on the original: it makes weaker assumptions, and it uses information about the design that the paper's own randomization protocol guarantees.

4.3.2 Implementation

```
obs_turnout <- coef(m1)["treat"]

set.seed(20260727)
null_turnout <- replicate(5000, {
  # ave() splits treat by commune and permutes within each block,
  # preserving 2 treated of 5 villages in every commune.
  df$treat_sim <- ave(df$treat, df$commune, FUN = sample)
  coef(feols(turnout ~ treat_sim | commune, data = df))["treat_sim"]
})

ri_p_turnout <- mean(abs(null_turnout) >= abs(obs_turnout))
```

```
obs_vs <- coef(v1)["treat"]

set.seed(20260727)
null_vs <- replicate(5000, {
  df$treat_sim <- ave(df$treat, df$commune, FUN = sample)
  coef(feols(voteshare ~ treat_sim | commune, data = df))["treat_sim"]
})

ri_p_vs <- mean(abs(null_vs) >= abs(obs_vs))
```

```
data.frame(
  Outcome            = c("Official turnout", "Official vote share"),
  Estimate           = c(obs_turnout, obs_vs),
  `Robust p-value`   = c(pvalue(m1)["treat"], pvalue(v1)["treat"]),
  `RI p-value`       = c(ri_p_turnout, ri_p_vs),
  check.names = FALSE, row.names = NULL
) |>
  kable(booktabs = TRUE, digits = 3,
```

```
        caption = "Asymptotic and randomization inference p-values. Randomization inference use
```

Table 4: Asymptotic and randomization inference p-values. Randomization inference uses 5,000 permutations of treatment within commune blocks.

Outcome	Estimate	Robust p-value	RI p-value
Official turnout	3.309	0.043	0.066
Official vote share	-0.196	0.927	0.923

```
tibble(estimate = null_turnout) |>
  ggplot(aes(x = estimate)) +
  geom_histogram(bins = 50, fill = "grey75", colour = "white") +
  geom_vline(xintercept = obs_turnout, linewidth = 0.7) +
  annotate("text", x = obs_turnout + 0.4, y = Inf, vjust = 2, hjust = 0,
           size = 3,
           label = paste0("Observed = ", round(obs_turnout, 2),
                          "\nRI p = ", round(ri_p_turnout, 3))) +
  labs(x = "Estimated treatment effect under the sharp null",
       y = "Frequency") +
  theme_minimal(base_size = 10)
```

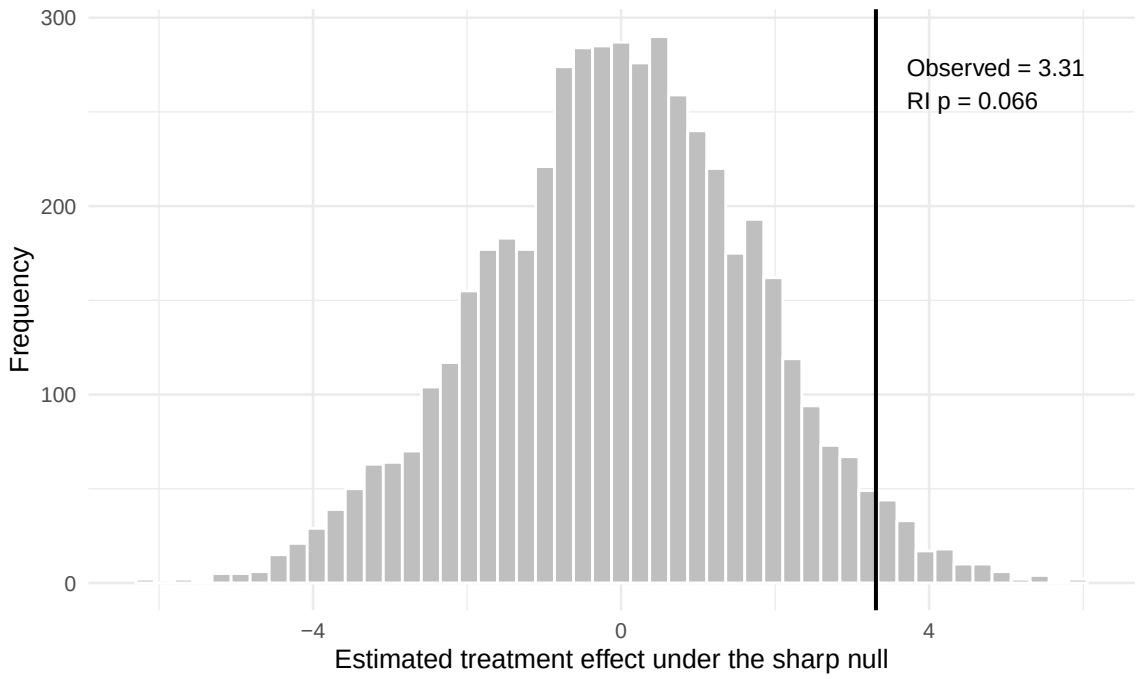


Figure 1: Randomization distribution of the turnout effect under the sharp null of no effect for any village. The vertical line marks the estimate obtained from the actual assignment.

4.3.3 Results

For turnout, randomization inference returns a p-value of 0.066, compared with 0.043 from the robust standard errors. The point estimate is unchanged, since randomization inference re-evaluates the evidence rather than the effect, but the two methods fall on opposite sides of the conventional 5 percent threshold. Under the procedure that uses the actual assignment mechanism, the turnout result is significant at the 10 percent level and not at the 5 percent level.

The size of this gap is larger than simulation noise can explain. With 5,000 permutations, the Monte Carlo standard error of the estimated p-value is approximately 0.0035, so the randomization inference p-value lies above 0.05 by several times its own simulation uncertainty.

For vote share the two methods agree almost exactly: 0.923 against 0.927. This pattern is informative. The divergence for turnout is not due to randomization inference returning larger p-values across the board; the two procedures coincide where the estimate is far from significance and diverge where the significance judgment is close. That is what one would expect if the large-sample approximation is adequate in general but slightly optimistic near the threshold in a sample of this size.

The conclusion is narrow and should not be overstated. A p-value of 0.066 is still moderately strong evidence against the sharp null, and the estimated effect remains 3.31 percentage points. What the extension establishes is that the paper's headline finding is more marginal than the reported asterisks suggest, and that its conventional significance depends on an inferential approximation rather than on the experimental design itself.

4.4 Extension 2: Disaggregating the pooled treatment

4.4.1 Motivation

The original paper reports results for "opposition" communes as a single category, pooling the two opposition candidates: Bio Tchané and the UN coalition. Pooling assumes the two treatments are interchangeable — that a town-hall meeting run by one had the same effect as one run by the other.

There is reason to question this. The two campaigns differed in ways that should plausibly interact with a deliberative format. Bio Tchané was a technocrat with an international financial career and relatively low prior name recognition, campaigning on detailed policy competence. The UN was an established opposition coalition with existing party structures and a leader already known to voters. If deliberation works by conveying platform information, a candidate whose platform is unfamiliar and detailed has more to gain from it than one whose reputation is already established.

As Table 1 shows, the two opposition candidates are also very unequally represented. Of the 110 villages in opposition communes, 90 — 82 percent — were assigned to the UN. Whatever the substantive comparison shows, the pooled "opposition" estimate is therefore driven primarily by the UN, and describing it as a general opposition effect overstates its generality.

4.4.2 Implementation and results

```
d1 <- feols(turnout   ~ yayi_treat + abt_treat + un_treat | commune,
            data = df, vcov = "hetero")
d2 <- feols(voteshare ~ yayi_treat + abt_treat + un_treat | commune,
            data = df, vcov = "hetero")
```

```
bind_rows(
  grab(d1, "yayi_treat", "Turnout: Yayi (incumbent)", communes = 8),
  grab(d1, "un_treat",   "Turnout: UN coalition",     communes = 18),
  grab(d1, "abt_treat",  "Turnout: Bio Tchané",       communes = 4),
  grab(d2, "yayi_treat", "Vote share: Yayi",          communes = 8),
  grab(d2, "un_treat",   "Vote share: UN coalition",  communes = 18),
  grab(d2, "abt_treat",  "Vote share: Bio Tchané",    communes = 4)
) |>
  kable(booktabs = TRUE, digits = 3,
        caption = "Candidate-specific treatment effects. Villages column reports the full esti
```

Table 5: Candidate-specific treatment effects. Villages column reports the full estimation sample; each coefficient is identified only within that candidate's communes.

Specification	Estimate	Std. Error	p-value	Villages	Communes
Turnout: Yayi (incumbent)	5.111	4.287	0.236	150	8
Turnout: UN coalition	3.463	1.764	0.052	150	18
Turnout: Bio Tchané	-0.989	3.392	0.771	150	4
Vote share: Yayi	-0.604	4.034	0.881	150	8
Vote share: UN coalition	0.007	2.368	0.998	150	18
Vote share: Bio Tchané	-0.295	8.963	0.974	150	4

The incumbent coefficients reproduce the incumbent-subsample estimates from Tables 2 and 3 exactly, with standard errors differing only trivially due to the small sample correction applied over the full sample. This serves as an internal check. Because the three candidates occupy disjoint sets of communes and commune fixed effects are included, estimating all three treatments jointly is equivalent to estimating each on its own subsample.

The decomposition shows that the paper's pooled opposition estimate of 2.653 conceals two quite different results. The UN coalition's effect is 3.46 percentage points ($p = 0.052$), close in magnitude to the overall treatment effect across all candidates, while Bio Tchané's is -0.99 with a standard error of 3.39. Pooling the two therefore attenuates the UN estimate rather than describing a common opposition effect. The Bio Tchané estimate should not be read as evidence that his town halls failed: its confidence interval spans roughly seven points in either direction, and as the test below reports, it is distinguishable neither from zero nor from the UN estimate.

The vote-share results, by contrast, are uniform. All three candidate-specific estimates are close to zero, which rules out the possibility that the aggregate null concealed offsetting effects across candidates. Disaggregation therefore strengthens rather than qualifies the paper's conclusion that deliberative campaigning did not redistribute votes.

The two opposition coefficients can be compared directly using the estimated covariance between them:

```
V  <- vcov(d1)
b  <- coef(d1)
```

```r
diff_est <- b["abt_treat"] - b["un_treat"]
diff_se  <- sqrt(V["abt_treat", "abt_treat"] +
                 V["un_treat",  "un_treat"]  -
               2 * V["abt_treat", "un_treat"])
diff_df  <- nobs(d1) - n_distinct(df$commune) - 3
diff_t   <- diff_est / diff_se
diff_p   <- 2 * pt(-abs(diff_t), df = diff_df)
```

```r
data.frame(
  Quantity      = "Bio Tchané minus UN (turnout)",
  Difference    = diff_est,
  `Std. Error`  = diff_se,
  `t`           = diff_t,
  `p-value`     = diff_p,
  check.names = FALSE, row.names = NULL
) |>
  kable(booktabs = TRUE, digits = 3,
        caption = "Test of equality between the two opposition candidates' turnout effects.")
```

Table 6: Test of equality between the two opposition candidates' turnout effects.

Quantity	Difference	Std. Error	t	p-value
Bio Tchané minus UN (turnout)	-4.452	3.823	-1.165	0.247

The estimated difference between the two opposition candidates is -4.45 percentage points (standard error 3.82, p = 0.247), with a 95 percent confidence interval of roughly [-11.9, 3]. The pooling assumption therefore cannot be rejected. This is a noisy null rather than an informative one. The point estimate is larger in magnitude than the pooled opposition effect itself, and the interval is wide enough to accommodate both exact equality and a substantial difference between the two campaigns. The source of the imprecision is structural. Bio Tchané's estimate rests on 4 communes and 20 villages, so its standard error is large by construction, and the test can detect only very large differences between candidates.

That limitation is the substantive point. The paper's opposition estimate is presented as a general finding about non-incumbent candidates, but 82 percent of the underlying villages belong to one coalition, and the experiment does not have the resolution to establish that the other opposition candidate's town halls worked similarly. A design with more balanced allocation across candidates would be required to test whether deliberation's effects depend on candidate type.

4.5 Further limitations

Three additional issues deserve mentioning.

First, the paper also reports effects on self-reported vote choice from a post-electoral survey, and these diverge sharply from the administrative results replicated here: a positive and highly significant effect of roughly seven percentage points on reported vote for the campaigning candidate, against the precisely estimated null from official returns. Two explanations are plausible. Respondents who

attended a town-hall meeting may report supporting that candidate because the meeting left a favorable impression or because it seems to be the expected answer, without changing their ballot. Alternatively, because the survey was conducted after treatment, the treatment may have altered who was available or willing to be interviewed, in which case the surveyed populations in treated and control villages are no longer comparable even though village assignment was random. Official returns are subject to neither problem, which is a reason to prefer the null result reported in Table 3 as the more credible estimate of the effect on vote choice.

Second, the villages in the experiment were not drawn at random from Benin as a whole. Each candidate selected communes from his own regional stronghold, so the estimates describe the effect of deliberation among voters already relatively favorable to the candidate. Whether town-hall meetings would mobilize voters in hostile territory is not addressed by this design.

Third, the no-interference assumption is more demanding than it appears. Villages within a commune are close together, and information about a town-hall meeting could easily reach neighboring control villages. If it did, control turnout is inflated and the estimates understate the true effect.

5 Conclusion

This paper replicated the two main village-level results of Wantchekon and Guardado (2024) and extended them in two directions.

The replication was exact. Both the turnout effect and the vote-share null reproduce to three decimal places, along with all four subsample estimates. The substantive pattern is that deliberative campaigning raised electoral participation by roughly 3.3 percentage points while leaving the campaigning candidate's vote share unchanged, with a confidence interval tight enough to rule out vote-share effects larger than about four points.

The first extension re-examined the statistical evidence for the turnout result using randomization inference within commune blocks. Because treatment was assigned by a known procedure, the sharp null can be tested directly by permuting assignment as it was actually carried out, without relying on a large-sample approximation. The resulting p-value of 0.066 places the headline finding outside the 5 percent threshold that the reported standard errors place it in. The effect size is unchanged and the evidence remains moderately strong, but the result is more marginal than the published table indicates. Notably, the two inference methods agree almost perfectly on the vote-share outcome, which suggests the divergence is specific to estimates near the significance boundary rather than a general property of the procedure.

The second extension replaced the pooled treatment indicator with candidate-specific ones. Since the three candidates campaigned in disjoint sets of communes, this decomposition is straightforward under the existing fixed effects. It shows that the result the paper reports for "opposition" candidates is driven overwhelmingly by a single coalition, which accounts for 82 percent of opposition villages, and that the experiment lacks the statistical resolution to establish whether the second opposition candidate's town halls performed comparably. Disaggregation cuts both ways: it weakens confidence in the pooled opposition turnout result while strengthening confidence in the vote-share null, which holds separately for every candidate.

Two implications follow. Substantively, the finding that deliberation mobilizes without persuading is the more robust of the paper's two results, since the null on vote share is precise and insensitive to the inference method, while the turnout effect is marginal under a stricter test. If that pattern

holds, it poses a real problem for the diffusion of deliberative campaigning: a format that raises participation without winning votes gives candidates little reason to adopt it. Methodologically, the case illustrates that in experiments of moderate size the reported significance of a marginal result can depend on whether inference relies on asymptotic approximations or on the randomization that the design actually performed. Where the assignment mechanism is known, the latter is available at very low cost and is worth reporting alongside conventional standard errors.

6 References

Wantchekon, Leonard, and Jenny Guardado. 2024. "Deliberation and Ethical Voting Behavior: Evidence from a Campaign Experiment in Benin." *American Political Science Review* 118(3): 1261–1277. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055423000813

Wantchekon, Leonard, and Jenny Guardado. 2023. "Replication Data for: Deliberation and Ethical Voting Behavior: Evidence from a Campaign Experiment in Benin." Harvard Dataverse. https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/PRYYZ5